

SIPRA DAS



**Vilasrao
Deshmukh**

CONGRESS

Maharashtra

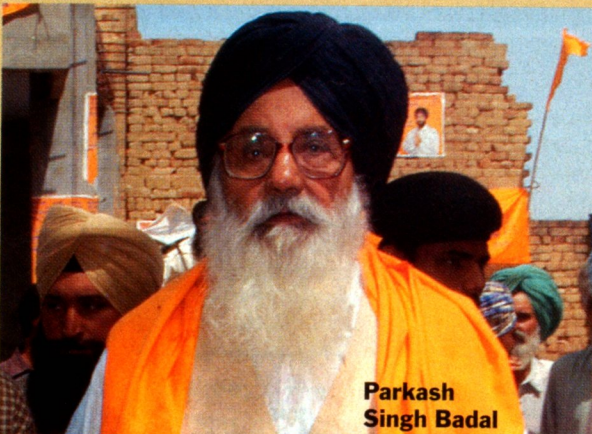
- Early disposal of 1992-93 riot cases.
- More funds allocated for housing for the poor.
- Free vocational classes for backward class students in government institutes.
- Power looms to get electricity on discount.
- Maternity homes to be built near medical centres in all villages.

AKALI DAL-BJP

Punjab

- BJP, which supported the hike in urban power tariffs, now wants a rollback, fearing a backlash.
- The Government claims developmental work worth Rs 50,000 crore will be launched in the next six months.
- An mou has been signed with the Delhi Metro for the Rs 3,000-crore rail project in Ludhiana.
- Farmers to be given a subsidy of Rs 100 per quintal for paddy during the ongoing procurement season.
- A Rs 800-crore scheme for providing subsidised atta and dal to 13 lakh families, who form a third of the state's population.

YASBANT NEGI



**Parkash
Singh Badal**

votebank. BJP, its alliance partner, which supported the hike in power tariffs for urban consumers, has suddenly backed out, fearing a backlash from its city-centric votebank. Akali Dal Vice-President and Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal's son Sukhbir Singh claims development projects worth Rs 50,000 crore are on the anvil.

In neighbouring Haryana, Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda took advantage of a Sonia Gandhi rally last week to announce a series of subsidies, which included residential plots for the Scheduled Caste and below poverty line families and low-cost housing for the urban poor. With elections in Himachal Pradesh slated for the second week of December, Chief Minister Virbhadr Singh is on electoral overdrive. Last week he clean forgot his 2006 promise of downsizing the Government, and sanctioned large-scale recruitments in the administration. As a sop to the farmers' lobby, he exempted stamp duty and registration fee on loans for agriculture and allied pursuits borrowed from any state-owned financial institution.

In West Bengal, the Left Front, which may well have precipitated early elections, is already off the blocks. It is using the Sachar Report to keep the minorities in good humour. After Singur and Nandigram, the contentious issue of land acquisition has been slowed down in areas where minorities are involved. While more and more state Government employees are taking home fatter paychecks, employment and educational reforms as well as land distribution plans are being redrawn.

Decisions taken by the state cabinet in Maharashtra read more like the common minimum programme of the Congress. Seeking to appease every critical section of the votebank, the Government is making high-decibel announcements every day. In order to decongest Mumbai and improve mass transit systems, Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh has approved the construction of four monorail corridors across the state capital, covering 70 km.

Populism has for long been the official policy of every party in power. When elections seem inevitable, as they do now, Union ministers and chief ministers embark on a please-all policy that is meant to bring a smile on the faces of voters and votes into the party's kitty. It isn't always that the first translates into the second.

with Satarupa Bhattacharjya and bureau inputs